IN THAT ORDER

Family, work, Masonry — and the mentor who understands why

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A guide to Masonic mentoring

Foreword

Mentoring is given a name nowadays, but in reality it has always been a core function of any society — and in particular our own ancient and honourable society. We are told that Freemasonry is about making good men better. What could be more fundamentally about mentoring than that?

Having joined Freemasonry in my early twenties, I have had the privilege of watching the Craft evolve over more than two decades. In the early days it did very much feel like a sink or swim environment — one where you were expected to stand on your own two feet, find your own way, and work things out as you went. But I think it is only fair to acknowledge that Freemasonry was not alone in this. A building site in the 1990s is a very different place to one in 2026. Society itself has changed, and the expectations we place on institutions — including voluntary ones — have changed with it. The Craft was a product of its time, as all things are.

But there is a difference between understanding why something was the way it was, and accepting that it should remain so.

One moment from my early Masonic life has stayed with me, and I suspect it always will. I had missed a few Lodge of Instruction evenings — not through lack of commitment, but because the demands of work and a 45-minute journey each way had simply made it impossible on those particular occasions. When I returned the following month, I was not met with warmth for being there. I was met with jokes about who I was, whether anyone remembered me, and remarks about my absence. No doubt those involved believed they were either just having a laugh, or in some parallel universe thought they were mentoring me — making clear that LOI attendance mattered and that I was expected to be there.

But it didn't inspire me to do better. It didn't make me want to be at LOI. It made me resentful.

Did they know what had been happening at work that made the journey impossible, however much I had wanted to come? Of course not — because nobody had asked. That experience has stayed with me throughout my adult life, and I made a quiet promise to myself that I would never do the same to another person. That inspiring people, encouraging people, and understanding people's circumstances was not a soft option — it was the only option that actually worked.

My early days in Freemasonry also taught me something else: that the Craft needs to be convenient. It needs to fit into a life that is already full. When I joined, I did so because a friend and colleague I respected was a Mason and invited me to his Lodge. What neither of us paused to consider was that while the Lodge was convenient for him, it most certainly was not convenient for me. LOI evenings meant a 45-minute journey on a good day, each way. Lodge nights meant long cab rides home at considerable expense. It was only later that I discovered there was a temple ten minutes from my house.

I appreciate that there are those who travel great distances for the love of the Craft and do so gladly. I know one Brother who travels from Edinburgh to Hertfordshire for Provincial duties, and does so with genuine enthusiasm and devotion. I respect that enormously. But these are the exception, not the rule, and we must be honest about that. It is my firm belief that during the candidate interview, we must ask not whether

the candidate is right for the Lodge, but whether the Lodge is right for the candidate. In times when retention is fragile and Lodges are working hard to attract new members, it can be an exciting moment when a prospective candidate appears on the horizon. Enthusiasm is a wonderful thing — but it must not blind us to the candidate's long-term needs. Bringing someone into a Lodge that doesn't suit their circumstances is not a success. It is the first step towards losing them altogether.

These experiences — the resentment, the inconvenience, the sense of being left to sink or swim — shaped everything I have come to believe about mentoring in Freemasonry. They are why this book exists.

In the years since, I have been fortunate to find in W.Bro Mark Butcher, Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire, both a mentor and a friend whose influence on my thinking has been profound. Mark's philosophy is simple, and simply stated: Freemasonry must be fun. It sounds almost too obvious to need saying — and yet, visit enough Lodges and you will find places where that truth has been quietly forgotten. Mark's mantra is not a licence to be frivolous. It is a reminder that men give their time freely, that the rewards of Freemasonry are personal rather than material, and that if a man does not enjoy his Masonic experience, no amount of ritual or tradition will keep him. That philosophy runs through every page of this book.

Together, Mark and I developed a framework for Masonic mentoring built around four principles: Prepare, Guide, Support, and Enlighten. These are not stages to be completed in sequence and then forgotten — they are continuous, overlapping responsibilities that accompany a Mason throughout his entire journey in the Craft. They form the structure of this book, and they are the lens through which I hope you will read it.

As I prepare to take on the role of Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire in 2027, I am more convinced than ever that mentoring is not a programme, a title, or an initiative. It is a culture. It is the expression of everything Freemasonry claims to stand for — brotherly love, relief, and truth — made real in the relationship between one man and another. Every Lodge has the capacity to be a place where men are welcomed, understood, supported, and inspired. This book is an attempt to help make that happen.

The question this book asks is not 'How do we keep members?' It is 'How do we make Freemasonry so rewarding that men never want to leave?'

The answer begins with you.

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Mentoring in Business and Mentoring in Freemasonry

What We Can Learn From Each Other

Walk into any well-run modern business and you will find mentoring embedded in the culture. Graduate schemes pair new recruits with experienced colleagues. Leadership programmes match emerging talent with senior figures who have navigated the same challenges a decade before. Line managers are trained not just to manage performance but to develop people — to ask better questions, to listen more carefully, and to help individuals find their own answers rather than simply handing them a solution. In the space of a generation, mentoring has moved from an informal arrangement between a willing senior and a grateful junior to a recognised discipline with its own literature, its own frameworks, and its own professional standards.

This is something Freemasonry should look at closely — not with envy, but with curiosity. Because the principles that make mentoring work in business are the same principles that make it work in the Lodge. And there is a great deal we can learn.

What modern business gets right

Running three businesses across very different sectors — event safety consultancy, event hire, and hospitality — has taught me that mentoring is not a luxury reserved for large corporations with dedicated HR departments. It is a necessity for any organisation that wants to develop its people rather than simply deploy them. The lessons I have learned along the way were rarely found in textbooks. They were found in conversations, in mistakes made and recovered from, in the slow realisation that the most effective thing a leader can do is invest time in another person's growth.

And the most valuable lessons, without exception, came from failure.

This is something business has increasingly come to understand and embrace. The best organisations — the ones that grow, that innovate, that retain good people — are not the ones where failure is hidden or punished. They are the ones where failure is examined, discussed, and learned from openly. Richard Branson, who has built one of the most recognisable business empires in the world, has spoken often about the importance of surrounding yourself with people who are better than you — people whose strengths complement your weaknesses, who will tell you when you are wrong, and who will push you further than you would push yourself. That philosophy is not a sign of weakness. It is the foundation of genuine leadership.

Masonic mentoring must adopt the same outlook. Failure in the Lodge — a forgotten word in ritual, a ceremony that did not go as planned, a mentoring conversation that missed the mark — is not something to be ashamed of. It is something to be learned from. The mentor who creates an environment in which his mentee is afraid to fail is not mentoring at all. He is simply adding another layer of pressure to a man who is already finding his feet in an unfamiliar world. The mentor who says, in effect, mistakes are expected, mistakes are how we grow, and I will be here when they happen — that mentor is doing something genuinely transformative.

Modern business mentoring tends to get several other things right that Freemasonry has historically struggled with.

It is intentional. Good businesses do not leave mentoring to chance, hoping that a new employee will somehow absorb what they need to know by osmosis. They create structures — induction programmes, regular one-to-ones, clear expectations about what a new person should know and by when. There is a plan, and someone is responsible for delivering it. This intentionality is something Masonic mentoring is increasingly embracing, and rightly so.

It is two-way. The best mentoring relationships in business are not lectures. The mentor does not simply pour knowledge into the mentee and send them on their way. They ask questions. They listen. They adapt their approach to the individual in front of them, recognising that what worked for one person may not work for another.

It is honest about failure. Modern business has largely moved away from the culture in which admitting a mistake was a sign of weakness. Good mentors in business create environments where it is safe to get things wrong, to ask a question that might seem obvious, to say 'I don't understand' without fear of being judged.

It understands that people are the product. In business, particularly in service industries, the quality of the people is the quality of the organisation. You cannot separate the organisation's success from the development of the individuals within it. Freemasonry is no different. The health of a Lodge is the health of its members — their engagement, their understanding, their enjoyment, their sense of belonging.

The myth of the hierarchy — circular mentoring

Here is something that took me time to fully understand, and that I believe is one of the most important ideas in this book.

Mentoring is not a hierarchy.

It is easy to think of it that way. The experienced Mason passes his knowledge down to the new one. Knowledge flows in one direction — from those who have it to those who need it. It is a tidy picture. It is also, in my experience, only half the truth.

My time working alongside W.Bro Mark Butcher, Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire, and W.Bro Robin Crozier has taught me that mentoring done well is not a one-way street. It is circular. The mentee teaches the mentor. The fresh perspective of a man encountering Freemasonry for the first time — his questions, his observations, his occasional bafflement at things the experienced Mason long ago stopped noticing — illuminates the Craft in ways that decades of familiarity cannot.

Branson's principle applies here with full force. Surround yourself with people who are better than you in some respect, and you will grow. A mentor who approaches his role with genuine humility — who is open to being surprised, challenged, or taught something he did not expect — will become a better Mason and a better mentor with every conversation he has.

This is not merely an abstract idea. It is something I have observed at every level of the Craft in Hertfordshire. W.Bro Keith Dunnett, our Assistant Provincial Grand Master, and RW Bro Neil Connolly, our Provincial Grand Master, are men who have given decades of distinguished service to Freemasonry. And yet both understand that

mentoring does not stop at the top of any structure. Even the most senior figures in the Craft have mentors — people whose counsel they seek, whose judgement they trust, and from whom they continue to learn. If the most experienced leaders in the Province recognise that the journey of learning and development never ends, then no Lodge Mentor, no new Mason, and no reader of this book should feel any differently.

Mentoring is not something that happens to you when you are new and stops when you become experienced. It is something you both give and receive, at every stage of your Masonic life.

Where Masonic mentoring goes further

For all that business mentoring has to teach us, Masonic mentoring has a dimension that no corporate programme can fully replicate.

In business, mentoring is almost always time-limited. The graduate scheme lasts two years. The leadership programme runs for twelve months. When the project ends, or the promotion comes, or one party moves on, the mentoring relationship typically concludes with it.

Masonic mentoring is lifelong.

The relationship between a mentor and his mentee does not end when the Third Degree is conferred, or when the mentee takes office, or even when he passes the Chair. It evolves. The questions a new Mason asks in his first year are not the same questions he will be asking five years later, and they are different again from the ones he will bring to his mentor when he is preparing for the Chair.

There is also a fundamental difference in motivation. In business, mentoring serves the organisation as much as the individual. In Freemasonry, there is no bottom line. There is no promotion to be gained, no salary to be increased, no performance review to be passed. A man mentors another man in the Lodge because he genuinely wants that person to flourish — in Freemasonry, and in life.

And then there is the festive board. No business has an equivalent. No corporate mentoring programme ends with the mentor and mentee sitting down together over a good meal, raising a glass, and simply enjoying the fellowship of good men. The festive board is not an add-on to the Masonic experience — it is central to it.

Borrowing the best of both

The argument of this chapter is not that business mentoring is better or worse than Masonic mentoring. It is that we have much to learn from each other, and that the most effective Masonic mentors are those who bring both together — the intentionality and structure of the modern professional approach, combined with the depth, longevity, and genuine human warmth that only a voluntary brotherhood can offer.

Don't be afraid to fail. Surround yourself with people who will make you better. Stay open to being taught by those you are teaching. These are not just business principles — they are Masonic ones. They are, when you think about it, precisely what the Craft has always asked of us. We are simply getting better at saying so out loud.

In the chapters that follow, you will find a framework for Masonic mentoring built around four principles — Prepare, Guide, Support, and Enlighten — that draws on exactly this combination. It is structured enough to be consistent and practical enough to be used. But it is always, at its heart, about one person choosing to invest in another. Not because they have to. Not because it is in their job description. But because that is what Brothers do.

Freemasonry Must Be Fun

There are five words that have shaped my understanding of Masonic mentoring more than any ritual, any lecture, or any Provincial guidance document. They were not delivered in a Temple. They were not accompanied by ceremony or formality. They are simply this:

Freemasonry must be fun.

They are the words of W.Bro Mark Butcher, Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire, and my own mentor. And the more I have sat with them — turning them over, testing them against experience, watching what happens in Lodges that embody them and Lodges that have forgotten them — the more convinced I have become that they are not just a pleasant sentiment. They are, in their way, the starting block from which the deeper journey begins.

What fun actually means

Let us be clear about what we are not saying. Fun does not mean frivolous. It does not mean that the ceremony should be treated lightly, that the ritual does not matter, or that the ancient traditions of our Order should be sacrificed on the altar of entertainment.

What it means — what Mark has always meant by it — is that a man should leave a Lodge meeting feeling better than when he arrived. He should leave enriched. He should leave with a sense of having been part of something worthwhile, having connected with people he is genuinely glad to know, having laughed at least once, and having been reminded why he joined in the first place.

Freemasonry must be fun is not the ceiling of what Masonry can offer a man. It is the floor — the minimum standard below which no Lodge should fall. It is the starting block from which the deeper journey begins. A man who is not enjoying his Masonry will never stay long enough to discover what Masonry can truly give him. But a man who is enjoying himself will keep coming back, and in coming back, he will find something he did not expect — something that goes far beyond enjoyment, into meaning, brotherhood, self-knowledge, and a connection to something ancient and enduring.

The festive board is not an afterthought

One of the most common mistakes made in discussions about Masonic quality is to treat the festive board as secondary to the ceremony. This is a misunderstanding of how Freemasonry actually works.

The festive board is not an afterthought. It is not the supporting act. For many members — and particularly for newer ones who are still finding their feet in the formality of the Lodge room — it is the most important part of the evening.

It is at the festive board that the new Mason first begins to feel that he belongs. The ceremony is powerful and moving, but it can also be overwhelming, filled with unfamiliar words and gestures and an atmosphere quite unlike anything else in modern life. The festive board is where the walls come down.

The social side of Masonry is a serious business. It is not peripheral to the Craft — it is the connective tissue that holds the Craft together.

Laughter is a tool

There is something else worth saying about fun, and it is this: laughter is not the enemy of dignity. It is one of its finest expressions.

The Lodge room calls for solemnity and respect, and rightly so. But Freemasonry is not confined to the Lodge room, and even within it there is more room for warmth and humanity than some traditions have allowed. A mentor who can make his mentee laugh — who can find the lightness in a difficult moment, who can defuse anxiety with a well-timed observation — is a more effective mentor than one who maintains an atmosphere of unrelenting gravity.

A Lodge that isn't fun won't survive

Men are not obliged to be there. They give their time freely, in the hours they might otherwise spend with their families, their friends, or simply at rest. If those hours do not return something of value — enjoyment, fellowship, meaning, laughter, belonging — they will eventually, quietly, stop giving them.

Every Lodge has the capacity to be a place where men genuinely want to be. It requires attention, intention, and the willingness to ask honestly: are we actually enjoying this?

A tribute

I want to say something directly about Mark Butcher, because this chapter would be incomplete without it.

Mark has served as Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire with a combination of wisdom, warmth, and quiet determination that has shaped the Province's approach to mentoring in ways that will be felt long after his tenure concludes. He has understood, before many others articulated it, that mentoring is not a function to be administered but a culture to be lived.

His mantra — Freemasonry must be fun — is deceptively simple. Four words that contain within them a complete philosophy of membership and human flourishing. Five words that challenge every Lodge officer, every mentor, and every experienced Mason to ask whether the experience they are offering is one that a reasonable man would genuinely value.

The philosophy is his. The responsibility to live it out belongs to all of us.

PART I

The Foundation

Understanding Mentoring in Freemasonry

Chapter One

Why Mentoring Matters

Picture two Lodges.

Both hold their meetings on the same night of the month. Both work the same ritual, under the same Constitution, in the same Province. Both have a Worshipful Master, a full set of officers, and a festive board that follows the ceremony. From the outside, they are essentially identical.

Inside, they could not be more different.

In the first Lodge, the atmosphere is warm before the meeting even begins. Men arrive early, not because they have to, but because they want to. There is laughter in the anteroom. The newer members are sought out, not left to find their own corner. The ceremony is performed with care and genuine feeling. At the festive board, the conversation flows freely across the table. Nobody is performing. Nobody is positioning. Everyone is simply glad to be there. A new member drives home thinking: I can't wait for next month.

In the second Lodge, the atmosphere is different. The newer members cluster together because nobody has thought to bring them into the wider group. The ceremony is technically accomplished but somehow airless. At the festive board, the conversation happens in established groups that a new member does not quite know how to enter. A new member drives home thinking: I'm not sure this is for me.

Both Lodges have members. Only one has a culture. And culture, in Freemasonry as in any human organisation, is not an accident. It is built — or neglected — through mentoring.

The gap between joining and understanding

There is a particular challenge that faces every man who enters Freemasonry: the gap between the moment of joining and the moment of truly understanding what he has joined is vast, and it cannot be crossed quickly.

The ceremonies of the three degrees are among the most extraordinary experiences available to a man in the modern world. They are also, to a man encountering them for the first time, completely bewildering. No man walks out of his Initiation ceremony with a clear understanding of what has just happened to him, what it means, or what is expected of him next.

Without someone to walk that road with him, many men will simply stop walking.

The world outside the Lodge

The man who joins a Lodge in 2026 is not the man who joined in 1986. His life is fuller, faster, and more demanding of his attention than at any previous point in the Craft's history. His leisure time is competed for by an extraordinary range of options that did not exist a generation ago.

He is not less committed than his predecessors. He is simply busier, and the competition for his time and attention is fiercer than it has ever been. This means that every Lodge meeting must earn its place in his diary. Not through obligation or guilt, but through genuine value.

Lodge character

W.Bro Jez Wilson, a good friend and fellow mentor, understands Lodge character as well as anyone I know. Old Hertfordians Lodge — Jez's Lodge — is a place that wears its identity proudly and unapologetically. Members wear their old school ties to meetings. They toast their school houses. They laugh, in their sixties, about sports days that happened forty years ago. And every year they play for the Errol Uttridge Cup — a friendly competition between Old Hertfordians and my own Lodge, Amwell — named in memory of W.Bro Errol Uttridge, a member of Amwell who was a permanently invited guest at Old Hertfordians and who shared a Chapter with both. The Cup keeps him present. It keeps the connection between the two Lodges alive in a way that no formal arrangement ever could.

Every Lodge has the capacity to develop this kind of character. Not every Lodge has chosen to cultivate it.

Mentoring in action — a story from Southampton

I want to tell you about an evening that has stayed with me, because it showed me what mentoring looks like when it is simply part of who a Lodge is.

I was visiting Gosport Lodge in Southampton for the Installation of a good friend, W.Bro Gareth Bezani. I had travelled down with two Brethren who had only recently been initiated. For both of them, this was just the second time they had walked into a Lodge room. Within moments of our arrival, the Lodge Mentor approached. He introduced himself, sat down alongside my two companions, and quietly, unhurriedly, began to explain what the evening would involve. When they would be asked to leave the room. When they would be invited back. What they would see. What would be expected of them. He did this not because anyone had asked him to, but simply because he saw two men who were new and responded to that fact with immediate, practical warmth.

And then the visiting Assistant Provincial Grand Master came over. He introduced himself, spoke with them briefly, and handed them each a small card bearing the words of the opening and closing odes — something to follow during the ceremony, something to keep.

Two gestures. Unplanned, unrehearsed, entirely natural. And between them, they transformed what could have been a bewildering evening into an experience those two Brethren will remember for the right reasons.

Gosport Lodge, on that evening, showed me something I already believed but had rarely seen so clearly demonstrated: that the best mentoring crosses every boundary — of Province, of Lodge, of acquaintance. Those two Brethren were strangers in that room. They left feeling welcomed. That is the standard every Lodge should hold itself to.

No one left in the corner

This principle — that no one should be left in the corner — is one that the founders of the Fleet House Light Blues Club understood instinctively. W.Bro Dan O'Connell, one of FHLBC's founding members, speaks about it with characteristic clarity. The Club was formed precisely because a man might join a Lodge where his father was already a member — a Lewis, proud to follow in his father's footsteps — and yet find himself surrounded by men a generation older, with no one his own age to connect with. FHLBC exists to solve that problem: to ensure that a young Mason can enjoy the tradition and ceremony of his own Lodge while reaching out across the Province to find Brothers of his own age and temperament.

That phrase — no one left in the corner — is, in its simplicity, a complete statement of what mentoring culture looks like in practice. It is not a programme. It is not a checklist. It is a choice, made every meeting night, to notice who is on the edge of the room and to go and find them.

When self-interest replaces brotherly interest

There is a shadow side to Lodge culture that any honest account of mentoring must acknowledge. It is the Lodge — or the individuals within it — where self-interest has quietly displaced brotherly interest. Where senior members steer candidates toward their own Lodges or degrees not because it is right for the candidate, but because it serves their own purposes. Where knowledge is guarded rather than shared. Where officers prioritise their own progression over the needs of the newer members who are watching and drawing conclusions about what kind of organisation this is.

The antidote is not condemnation — it is culture. A Lodge with a strong mentoring culture, in which the experienced genuinely invest in the new, in which knowledge is something to be given rather than hoarded, makes self-interest difficult to sustain, because the culture itself keeps pulling in the opposite direction.

The Lodge that mentors well is the Lodge that inspires. And the Lodge that inspires is the Lodge that men do not want to leave.

Chapter Two

What a Masonic Mentor Is (and Isn't)

Before we can talk about how to mentor well, we need to be clear about what mentoring actually is. The confusion around the role — what it involves, where it begins, where it ends, and who is responsible for what — is one of the most common reasons that mentoring in a Lodge fails to deliver what it should.

What a Masonic mentor is

A Masonic mentor is, first and most fundamentally, a friend. Not a line manager. Not an assessor. The moment a mentee begins to feel that his mentor is monitoring him rather than supporting him, the relationship is compromised.

A Masonic mentor is a guide, not a teacher. The distinction matters. A teacher has a curriculum — a defined body of knowledge that must be transferred from one person to another by a set point in time. A guide has a direction and a companion. He knows the territory because he has walked it himself. He does not walk the journey for his mentee, and he does not carry him.

A Masonic mentor is a listener, not a lecturer. This is perhaps the hardest discipline for experienced Masons to maintain, because experience creates the temptation to share it. The mentor who listens — who asks a question and then waits, genuinely, for the answer — will learn things that transform the relationship.

A Masonic mentor is a long-term companion, not a short-term fixer. The mentoring relationship does not conclude when the Third Degree is conferred. It evolves.

What a Masonic mentor is not

A Masonic mentor is not a gatekeeper. The gatekeeping mentality — the belief that knowledge should be rationed, that the new Mason should be kept in a state of managed ignorance until the experienced Mason decides he is ready — is one of the most damaging patterns in Lodge culture. A mentor opens doors. He does not stand in front of them.

A Masonic mentor is not a substitute for other roles. The Lodge has an Almoner and a Membership Officer. The mentor is not expected to absorb their functions. Knowing when to refer, and who to refer to, is itself a mark of good mentoring.

And a Masonic mentor is not someone whose job ends at the Third Degree.

The Lodge Mentor and the Personal Mentor — a crucial distinction

The Lodge Mentor is the Lodge's strategic coordinator of mentoring. He attends meetings with other Lodge Mentors at Provincial level. He understands the Provincial mentoring strategy and ensures that his Lodge is aligned with it. He oversees the mentoring process across the whole Lodge, checking in with Personal Mentors,

identifying where support is needed, and ensuring that no member falls through the gaps.

The Personal Mentor is the one-to-one relationship. He is the person a new Mason meets with, talks to, calls when he has a question, sits with at the festive board, and turns to when something about his Masonic experience is confusing or concerning.

In Amwell Lodge, we have moved deliberately away from the assumption that a man's Personal Mentor should automatically be his sponsor. The sponsor relationship is one of introduction and vouching. The mentoring relationship requires a particular combination of personality, availability, patience, and skill that not every sponsor possesses. We make considered appointments of Personal Mentors — matching individuals thoughtfully, based on personality, shared interests, availability, and the particular needs of the new member.

The Mentor's Jewel

In Hertfordshire, the appointment of a Lodge Mentor is marked by the presentation and explanation of the Mentor's Jewel.

The Jewel consists of two chisels in saltire. The chisel is the tool of the craftsman — the instrument of precision, of shaping, of careful and deliberate work. The crossed chisels reflect the duality at the heart of every mentoring relationship — the mentor's guidance and the mentee's own effort are both necessary. Neither is sufficient alone.

The explanation of the Jewel reminds the newly appointed Lodge Mentor of his purpose:

The Lodge Mentor's job is to Prepare, Guide, Support and Enlighten the members on their Masonic journey. But this responsibility does not lie solely with the Lodge Mentor — he should therefore ensure that every member has a Personal Mentor to support them. Because, Brethren, we are all Mentors and must take ownership of our future.

And it concludes with a toast:

Here's to your health — and may Freemasonry flourish, root and branch.

The Jewel is not presented to one man. The message belongs to all of them.

Chapter Three

The Mentor's Qualities

Nobody is born a good mentor. The qualities that make a genuinely effective mentor are not the automatic by-products of time served in the Craft. They are developed, cultivated, and — crucially — they begin with an honest examination of oneself.

Freemasonry has always understood this. The great theme of the Craft is self-improvement. The ashlar — rough at first, worked upon over time until it becomes fit for the builder's use — is not merely a metaphor for the candidate. It is a metaphor for every Mason, at every stage of his journey, including the most experienced.

Positivity breeds positivity

I have been in Lodges where the atmosphere is generous and warm, where experienced Masons genuinely delight in the progress of newer ones. And I have been in Lodges where the atmosphere is guarded and competitive, where knowledge is currency and currency is hoarded.

The difference between these two environments is not accidental. It is the cumulative result of choices made, over time, by the people within them. Positivity breeds positivity. A Lodge in which the senior Masons are generous with their knowledge, warm in their welcome, and genuinely invested in others' growth will, over time, produce members who behave the same way.

The qualities that matter most

Humility is the foundation of everything else. Not false modesty, but the genuine recognition that knowledge is always incomplete, that experience creates blind spots as well as insights, and that the person sitting across from you may have something to teach you that you did not expect.

Curiosity — a good mentor is genuinely interested in this person, sitting here, with this particular history and these particular questions. Curiosity is what drives the mentor to ask the second question — the one that goes beyond the surface answer.

Honesty — good mentoring requires honesty, and honesty sometimes requires courage. The mentor who only ever tells his mentee what he wants to hear is not a mentor — he is a flatterer.

The gift of constructive conflict

There is a quality that sits alongside honesty and is often confused with its opposite: the willingness to disagree.

W.Bro Mark Purtow, Assistant Provincial Grand Master of Hertfordshire, has mentored me in a way that I want to describe carefully, because it illustrates something about mentoring that most books on the subject either overlook or actively discourage.

Mark has never simply agreed with me. He has asked me questions that challenged decisions I had already made. He has pushed back on positions I was confident about.

He has, on more than one occasion, caused me to go away and think again about something I thought was settled. And he has done all of this in the context of a relationship built on genuine trust and mutual respect — the phone calls that arrive at the right moment, the quiet conversations that carry more weight than their brevity suggests, the small acts that speak loudly about the nature of the relationship. When Mark asked me to carry the pillow at the Provincial Grand Meeting — the pillow on which his chain of office was placed — it was not a grand gesture. It was a signal. A quiet, considered act of trust that said, without words, that this relationship is real and I value it.

I quite often disagree with Mark. And I remind him — and anyone else who will listen — that no good decision was ever made by people who always agree.

This needs to be said plainly, because Lodge culture — and mentoring culture within it — has a tendency toward deference. The newer Mason defers to the more experienced one. The mentee defers to the mentor. The junior officer defers to the senior. And deference, when it becomes habitual, produces an environment in which the narrative is never questioned, the boundaries are never pushed, and the decisions made are the decisions that make everyone comfortable rather than the decisions that are actually right.

Being surrounded by people who always say yes is not a healthy environment. It is a comfortable one, which is an entirely different thing. Comfort and health are not the same, in organisations any more than in bodies. The organisation that never encounters internal challenge does not grow stronger — it grows brittle. The mentor whose mentee never disagrees with him has not earned the mentee's respect. He has simply made disagreement feel unsafe.

The mentor who creates space for constructive conflict — who welcomes the challenge, who does not interpret disagreement as disloyalty, who understands that a mentee who pushes back is a mentee who is genuinely engaged — is doing something more valuable than the mentor who simply dispenses wisdom to a grateful recipient. He is building a relationship strong enough to carry the weight of honesty.

I use the word conflict deliberately, and I mean it in the most constructive possible sense. Not aggression. Not confrontation. Not the kind of disagreement that damages relationships or closes conversations. But the productive friction of two minds engaging honestly with the same question and arriving at different answers — and having the courage and the trust to say so.

Mark Purtow has given me three things through his mentoring, and I have come to understand that they are the same thing described three different ways. He has challenged me as well as supported me. He has shown his trust through small acts as much as through grand ones. And he has created a space in which disagreement is not just permitted but valued — a space in which the relationship is stronger, not weaker, for the moments when we do not see things the same way.

That is what a mentor at the highest level looks like. Not someone who tells you what you want to hear. Someone who trusts you enough to tell you what you need to hear — and who has built a relationship solid enough that you can do the same in return.

Self-awareness — the self-aware mentor knows how he comes across. He knows whether he has a tendency to talk too much, to offer solutions when he should be asking questions, to let his own strongly held views colour the guidance he gives.

The mentor who protects his own position

In any organisation — and Freemasonry is no exception — there exists a particular type of person whose involvement in others' development is subtly shaped by self-interest. He shares enough to appear generous. He guides enough to appear helpful. But he does not open every door. He does not fully invest in making his mentee as capable, as knowledgeable, or as well connected as he himself is — because somewhere, beneath the surface, he has confused his own value with his indispensability.

The antidote is the quality we began with: humility. The mentor who is genuinely humble will never fall into this pattern. His success is measured not by how much he knows, but by how much he gives away.

Seniority is not suitability

Let us be plain: the length of time a man has been a Mason is not, by itself, a qualification for mentoring. Seniority brings experience, and experience has real value. But seniority also brings habits, assumptions, and a familiarity with Lodge culture so deep that it can become invisible.

Appointing mentors on the basis of seniority alone is a disservice both to the mentor and to the mentee, who deserves better.

The examined life

The mentor who takes this seriously — who applies to himself the same standard of honest self-examination that he hopes to encourage in his mentee — will find that the mentoring relationship makes him better. It will sharpen his self-awareness, deepen his humility, and remind him that the journey of Masonic self-improvement has no final destination.

Positivity breeds positivity. Generosity breeds generosity. And the mentor who gives fully — of his time, his honesty, his curiosity, and his humility — will find that he receives, in return, more than he expected.

PART II

The New Mason's Journey

Walking in Their Shoes

Chapter Four

The World Before the Lodge

Every man who sits in a Lodge room tonight was, not so long ago, standing outside it.

He was living his life — working, raising a family, maintaining friendships, navigating the ordinary complexity of a modern existence — with no particular knowledge of what went on behind the doors of the building he may have passed a hundred times without thinking much about. And then something changed.

Why men come to Freemasonry

Men arrive at the door of a Lodge by many different roads, and a good mentor understands that the road a man has travelled shapes what he needs when he arrives.

Some come through family connection. A father was a Mason, or a grandfather, whose regalia was found in a box after he died and prompted a conversation that led, eventually, to a petition. Some come through friendship — a colleague they respect invited them and they said yes. Some come through curiosity — men who have sought Freemasonry out themselves, who have read about it, researched it, approached the Provincial office or the national website. And some come seeking brotherhood — a desire for genuine connection with other men, for a space in which something more than surface-level sociability is on offer.

The misconception that does most damage

Of all the misunderstandings a man can bring with him to the Lodge, the most damaging — and the most persistent — is the belief that Freemasonry is an old boys' network: a vehicle for career advancement, a room full of men doing each other professional favours, a system of mutual benefit dressed up in aprons and ritual.

The man who joins expecting his business to benefit will find, fairly quickly, that this is not what Freemasonry is. The candidate interview is one of the most important opportunities to address this misconception directly, honestly, and before the petition is signed.

Mentoring begins at the point of interest

Here is a principle that runs counter to how most Lodges currently think about mentoring: the mentoring relationship does not begin at Initiation. It does not begin at the interview. It begins at the point of interest — the moment a man first indicates that he is curious about Freemasonry.

That first conversation — in a car, over a coffee, at a kitchen table — is already a mentoring moment. The Mason answering those questions is, whether he realises it or not, already shaping the candidate's experience.

The right Lodge for the right man

It is my firm belief that the candidate interview should ask not whether the candidate is right for the Lodge, but whether the Lodge is right for the candidate. A man in his late twenties, newly married, building a career, with limited evenings available, may not thrive in a Lodge whose membership is predominantly in its sixties, however warm and welcoming that Lodge may be.

The mentor — or the prospective mentor, at this early stage — must be willing to ask the question that self-interest might otherwise suppress: is my Lodge actually the right place for this man?

The four principles, before the first degree

The four principles of Masonic mentoring — Prepare, Guide, Support, and Enlighten — do not begin at Initiation. They are already fully operational in the period before a man ever enters the Lodge room as a member.

Prepare means ensuring the applicant understands every practical aspect of what lies ahead: the process and its timeframes, the format and location of the interview, the dress code, who will be present and what their roles in the Lodge are, the time and financial commitments that Freemasonry will ask of him.

Guide means signposting him to reliable sources of information — the UGLE website, the Hertfordshire Provincial website, the Masonic Charitable Foundation — and understanding what he himself is looking for.

Support means checking in. Asking whether he needs any help with the process, whether there are any needs that should be accommodated, ensuring he has everything he needs. A brief contact the day before the interview — not to brief him further, but simply to say: we are thinking of you, we are glad you are coming.

Enlighten means beginning, gently and appropriately, to introduce him to what Freemasonry actually stands for. The four guiding principles — Integrity, Friendship, Respect, and Service. The ceremonies, he can be told, are built around three great themes: looking after those less fortunate, improving oneself, and living life well enough to be remembered for the right reasons.

The new Mason who has been mentored through his applicant journey arrives at his Initiation not as a stranger stepping into the unknown, but as someone who has already been prepared, guided, supported, and enlightened.

Chapter Five

The Shock of the New

The morning after his Initiation, a new Mason wakes up as a member of the oldest and most widespread fraternal organisation in the world. He is part of a brotherhood that spans continents, that counts among its historical members some of the most significant figures in the story of Western civilisation, that has been meeting — in one form or another — for centuries before he was born and will continue meeting for centuries after he is gone.

He probably has no idea.

The two shocks

There are, in fact, two distinct shocks that a new Mason may experience in the weeks after his Initiation, and they pull in opposite directions.

The first is the shock of overwhelm. The ceremony was intense, layered, and mysterious. He feels, at the festive board and in the Lodge room, that everyone around him is operating from a shared understanding that he has not yet been given access to.

The second shock is less often talked about, but in my experience it is at least as common and considerably more damaging. It is the shock of underwhelm.

The new Mason who arrives at his first Lodge of Instruction expecting to begin the work of becoming a Mason — who has cleared his diary, explained to his partner that he will be out on a weeknight — and who is then told, within five minutes of arriving, that there is nothing for him tonight and he should go home. Or who turns up and finds the meeting postponed. Or who is told that the Lodge is preparing for an installation and there is no work for an Entered Apprentice this month.

This man goes home not overwhelmed but deflated. He made the effort. The commitment, on that particular evening, was not there to meet him.

Managing expectations — in both directions

The solution to both shocks is the same: honest, thoughtful preparation. The new Mason who is overwhelmed needs to be told, clearly and warmly, that this is entirely normal — that nobody understands everything the first time, that the ceremony is designed to be experienced many times, and that his questions are not a sign of inadequacy but a sign of engagement.

The new Mason who risks underwhelm needs an honest, realistic account of what the early months of Masonry actually look like in practice. Not the version in which every meeting is richly meaningful, but the real version.

The first LOI

Of all the early mentoring moments in a new Mason's journey, the one that carries the most potential — for good or for ill — is the first Lodge of Instruction. For a new Entered Apprentice, this transition can be disorienting. The officers may be in

different positions. The atmosphere is more relaxed. People correct each other, start again, occasionally laugh. It is a rehearsal — and the new Mason who expected a continuation of the ceremony's grandeur may find it unexpectedly ordinary.

This is precisely where a mentor earns his place. That phone call or message — just to let you know, tonight there won't be much for you as an EA, but come along anyway and I'll introduce you to a few people — is a small act. It is also an act of respect.

Understanding the scale of what he has joined

Amid all the practical challenges of the early weeks, there is something else a new Mason needs, and it is perhaps the greatest gift a mentor can give him: an understanding of the scale of what he has joined.

Not the complexity — that will reveal itself over time. But the sheer scope and depth of Freemasonry as a human institution. The fact that he is now part of a brotherhood that stretches across the world, that connects him to men of every background, profession, and nationality who share the same values and the same obligations.

He has not simply joined a Lodge. He has joined a tradition.

The questions he is afraid to ask

Every new Mason has them. The questions that feel too basic to voice, too obvious to admit not knowing the answer to. These questions do not get asked, in many Lodges, because no one has made it clear that they are welcome.

The mentor's most important task in these early weeks is not to deliver information. It is to create the conditions in which questions feel safe. The Brother who feels he can ask anything of his mentor is the Brother who will keep learning.

PART III

Working the Degrees Together

The Heart of the Relationship

Chapter Six

Stages of Growth

The Masonic journey is not a straight line. It does not move at a uniform pace, in a single direction, toward a destination that is the same for every man. It is personal — shaped by who the man is, what he brings to it, what his life outside the Lodge allows, and what he finds when he looks inward at the things the Craft keeps placing before him.

Understanding this is one of the most important things a mentor can do. Not because it excuses a Lodge from creating meaningful experiences and opportunities for growth, but because it prevents the Lodge from measuring every man against the same ruler and finding some of them wanting.

The journey that is often rushed

One of the most persistent failures in Masonic mentoring is the pressure to progress. The assumption — sometimes implicit, sometimes entirely explicit — that the Entered Apprentice should be passed to the Fellow Craft as soon as the Lodge's programme permits, and that the Fellow Craft should be raised as soon as the schedule allows.

This is the Lodge's convenience masquerading as the member's progression. They are not the same thing.

Every man moves through the degrees at his own pace. Some absorb the First Degree's lessons quickly and are genuinely ready for the Second within months. Others need longer — not because they are less capable, but because the experience has given them more to sit with, more to reflect on, more questions to resolve before they are ready to move forward. The mentor who knows his mentee well enough to understand which kind of man he is dealing with is the mentor who can advocate for the right pace — diplomatically, firmly, and always in the mentee's interest rather than the Lodge's.

Different men find different things

It is also worth saying plainly that not every Mason wants to progress through the offices. Not every Brother is drawn to ritual delivery. Not every man who joins a Lodge does so because he wants to stand up in front of people and perform.

Some men love the LOI, love the fellowship, love watching the ceremony from the sidelines and enjoying the festive board, but have no desire — and perhaps a genuine inability, whether through shyness, a reading difficulty, or simple temperament — to deliver ritual in a formal setting. That man is a perfectly good Mason. A Lodge that makes him feel like a failure for not progressing is losing something valuable and telling him, implicitly, that his version of Freemasonry is not valid.

I have known men who left Freemasonry because the Lodge pushed them into an office they were not ready for. The Inner Guard, the Junior Deacon, the Senior Warden — positions that carry real responsibility and require real confidence — offered to men who had not yet developed the confidence to hold them, and who experienced the pressure to accept as a reason to leave rather than a vote of confidence.

The mentor who pays attention to this — who asks, genuinely, what his mentee enjoys and what he finds difficult, and who advocates accordingly — prevents these losses before they happen.

The journey beyond the Third Degree

The Third Degree is not the end of the journey. It is, if anything, the point at which the real journey begins. The Master Mason who looks up from the summit finds that the view is wider than he expected.

There is the Lodge to serve. There is the Province — its meetings, its events, its community of Masons from across Hertfordshire. There is the Royal Arch — the completion of Pure Antient Masonry, which UGLE describes as inseparable from the Craft itself. And there are, beyond all of these, the years of learning, reflection, and service that make a Master Mason not just a title but a way of being in the world.

The mentor's role does not end when the Third Degree is conferred. It evolves. The questions that arise after the raising are different in kind from those that came before — about direction, about meaning, about how to contribute rather than simply how to belong. They deserve the same quality of attention, the same consistency of presence, the same genuine interest in the person asking them.

Measuring progress by the right standard

The danger of measuring progress only by ritual achievement — by how quickly a man has moved through the degrees, how many offices he has held, how perfectly he delivers his work — is that it measures the wrong thing. It measures performance rather than development. It measures what is visible rather than what is real.

The right standard is simpler, and harder to quantify: is this man growing? Is he more engaged, more curious, more connected to the Craft and to his Brethren than he was a year ago? Does he look forward to Lodge nights? Does he leave them feeling better than when he arrived?

If the answers to those questions are yes, the Lodge is doing its job — regardless of whether the man in question has progressed to the Second Degree, delivered a piece of ritual, or taken an office. And if the answers are no, no amount of ceremonial progress makes up for what is missing.

Chapter Seven

The First Degree: Lessons in Humility and Trust

There is a moment, in the weeks before a man's Initiation, when the mentoring relationship earns its first real test. The candidate has been accepted, the date has been set, and the ceremony is approaching. He knows enough to be curious and not enough to be calm. He is, in all likelihood, quietly anxious — and he may not be saying so.

This is where the mentor steps forward. Not with a briefing document or a formal agenda, but with a conversation. A real one. The kind that asks not just what the candidate knows, but who he is, what he needs, and what might make the difference between an evening that goes smoothly and one shadowed by an avoidable difficulty.

I have learned, from long experience, that the most important preparation a mentor can do before the First Degree has nothing to do with ritual or symbolism. It is about the human details that nobody else thinks to ask about.

I once helped prepare a friend for his Initiation — a man of generous proportions, who had decided to mark the occasion by buying a new suit. What he had not considered was that the ceremony would require him to roll up his trouser leg. A slim-fitting suit, purchased for a formal occasion, would have created an uncomfortable and undignified struggle at precisely the wrong moment. A quiet word in advance, delivered with warmth and without embarrassment, resolved the situation entirely.

Another candidate wore glasses for reading. He would need them during the ceremony. A gentle reminder beforehand meant they were in his pocket when he needed them.

A third was unable to kneel due to a health condition. The right response — the Masonic response — is to adapt the ceremony with care and dignity, so that the man's physical limitation is quietly accommodated rather than made into a moment that sets him apart. We did exactly that. He was Initiated with the same dignity as any other Brother.

These are small things. They are also everything.

The mentor's role on the night

On the evening of the Initiation itself, the Personal Mentor has a clear and important purpose: to be present, to be calm, and to ensure that the candidate's experience begins well before he enters the Temple. This means arriving early. It means being the familiar face in the anteroom. It means making introductions — to the Tyler, to the Inner Guard, to the Junior Deacon, who will guide him through the ceremony.

The Hertfordshire approach is clear: explain the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail, ensure the dress code and etiquette are covered, and offer the most important practical reassurance of all — everyone has done this, arrive early, relax, and you will be guided at every step.

What the ceremony gives and what it withholds

The First Degree ceremony is one of the most remarkable experiences available to a man in the modern world. It will also, almost certainly, leave him with more questions than answers. This is by design. The ceremony is not a lecture. It reveals itself gradually, over repeated exposure and deepening understanding.

The mentor who understands this will resist the temptation to over-explain. The candidate who has just experienced the First Degree does not need an immediate seminar on its symbolism. He needs time and space to absorb what has happened.

The conversation after

The most important mentoring conversation of the First Degree does not happen on the night. It happens in the days that follow. A phone call or a message — ideally within forty-eight hours — that asks simply: how are you getting on? How did you find it? Is there anything you want to talk about?

This conversation matters for several reasons. It signals that the mentor's interest did not end when the candidate left the Lodge room. It creates the first opportunity for the new EA to ask the questions that have been forming since the ceremony.

The four principles at the First Degree

Prepare means explaining the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail. Etiquette, dress code, punctuality, mobile phone off, cash. Ensuring he knows he will be expected to speak at the festive board. Practical tips — everyone has done this, arrive early, relax, you will be guided at every step.

Guide means introducing him to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon. Explaining that the purpose of initiation is the symbolic beginning of his Masonic journey. The Masonic values of Integrity, Friendship, Respect and Service. Expectations around attendance, contribution, charity and festive boards. The social side, the importance of friendship and the Fleet House Light Blues Club. Signposting to Solomon for further study. Encouraging visiting another Lodge's initiation.

Support means explaining the Masonic journey after the First Degree. Reassuring that questions are encouraged, with mentors and Brethren available after the ceremony. Introducing him to the Lodge and his Personal Mentor, and explaining what a mentor does. Reassuring that the ceremony is symbolic, safe and conducted with dignity and respect. Identifying questions leading to the Second Degree. Explaining what the Lodge of Instruction is.

Enlighten means exploring the moral themes of the First Degree — Faith, Hope, Charity, Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence and Justice. Encouraging reflection on how the lessons apply personally. Emphasising the wider role of Freemasonry in supporting communities. Explaining that there are three degrees, each building on the last, with opportunities for personal growth. DAWG — the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team — keeps Masonic learning alive between meetings.

Chapter Eight

The Second Degree: Knowledge, Learning and the Examined Mind

There is a moment in the Second Degree ceremony that does not get talked about enough. It is not the most dramatic moment of the evening. It is, on the surface, a simple exchange — a question asked, an answer given, a short phrase spoken by the Worshipful Master in response.

Very well answered, Worshipful Master.

For the man standing in the Lodge room when those words are spoken — standing there because he prepared, because his mentor supported him, because he was ready — it is the first moment of genuine public achievement in his Masonic life.

It is a moment worth waiting for. It is not a moment worth rushing.

The forgotten degree

The Second Degree occupies an awkward position in the Masonic journey. It sits between the drama of the First and the profound gravity of the Third. Between those two peaks, the Second Degree can feel, if it is not carefully handled, like a corridor. This does the degree a serious injustice.

Its themes are intellectual — the pursuit of knowledge, the development of reason, the building of character through study and diligence. The mentor's first task at this stage is to help the Fellow Craft understand that he is not simply passing through. He has arrived somewhere.

The question of readiness

The Second Degree is the first ceremony in which the candidate is required to perform in open Lodge. He must answer questions — questions that he will have learned, with his mentor's support, in the weeks and months since his Initiation.

Performance anxiety is real, and it does not discriminate. The mentor who rehearses with his Fellow Craft — who creates the conditions in which practice is possible without embarrassment, who reassures that everyone finds it daunting — gives his mentee something invaluable.

Readiness, not convenience

Here is something that needs to be said plainly: the Fellow Craft should be passed to the Third Degree when he is ready. Not when it fits into the Lodge's schedule. Not when there happens to be a convenient ceremony slot.

If a Fellow Craft is not ready to be passed, the right response is to wait. And in the meantime, to do something else. A demonstration degree. A lecture on the degree's themes and symbolism. There are always options. There is never a good reason to rush a man through a ceremony he is not ready for, because what he will remember is not the ceremony — it will be the anxiety.

The four principles at the Second Degree

Prepare means explaining the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail. Ensuring he knows he will need to answer questions in Lodge and offering help with practising. Practical reassurance — everyone has done this, arrive early, trust that he will be guided and supported by the officers throughout.

Guide means re-introducing him to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon. Explaining that the purpose of advancement is to build on the symbolic foundation laid in the First Degree. Revisiting the Masonic values and discussing how they deepen through knowledge. Expectations around attendance, contribution, charity and active participation. Encouraging visiting another Lodge's Second Degree.

Support means explaining that the Masonic journey continues beyond the Second Degree. Reinforcing that questions are encouraged. Reassuring that ritual can take as long as each individual needs — do not feel overwhelmed. Beginning to identify areas of curiosity leading to the Third Degree. Highlighting the value of Lodge of Instruction.

Enlighten means discussing the moral and intellectual themes of the Second Degree — the pursuit of knowledge, the development of reason, the building of character. Encouraging reflection on how the lessons of diligence, study and self-improvement apply personally and professionally. After the meeting, discussing the working tools up to the Second Degree and their symbolic meaning. Discussing the apron and the next steps of a Master Mason's apron. DAWG administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team.

Chapter Nine

The Third Degree: Mortality, Meaning and the Master Mason

There is no ceremony in Craft Freemasonry quite like the Third Degree.

This is not simply a matter of drama, though it is dramatic. It is something more fundamental — a ceremony that asks a man to confront, directly and without evasion, the one truth that every human life is built around and that modern life works so hard to avoid: that he will die. That his time is finite. That the question of how he lives, and what he leaves behind, and whether he has been the kind of man he set out to be — these are not questions for some distant future. They are questions for now.

The balance of preparation

How much should a mentor prepare a candidate for the Third Degree? The right answer lies in balance. Prepare the man practically and emotionally. Tell him that the ceremony is powerful, that it is unlike what has come before, that it will ask something of him that the previous degrees did not. Tell him that it is entirely safe, symbolic, and has been performed with dignity and reverence for centuries. Tell him to arrive well rested and having eaten. And then step back. Let the ceremony do what it is designed to do.

What the degree asks a man to confront

The Third Degree is, at its heart, a meditation on mortality. This is not something that Freemasonry apologises for or softens. It places mortality at the centre of the ceremony deliberately, because it believes that a man who has genuinely reckoned with his own death is a better man than one who has not.

The mentor's role in the days after the ceremony is to open this conversation — gently, without forcing it, in a way that meets the new Master Mason where he is.

The Master Mason's apron

Among the tangible, visible expressions of progression in Freemasonry, few carry more significance than the apron. The Master Mason's apron tells a story worth taking the time to tell well.

In some Lodges, the explanation of the Master Mason's apron is delivered as part of an extended working. The seven tassels that adorn the apron are among the richest details. Seven is a number of ancient significance in Masonic symbolism — it appears in the seven liberal arts and sciences, and in the seven planetary bodies that the ancient world knew: the Sun, the Moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn. These seven celestial bodies were, for millennia, the boundaries of human knowledge about the cosmos. That their number echoes through the symbolism of the Master Mason's apron connects the man wearing it to something vast and ancient — a tradition of enquiry that stretches back far beyond the founding of any Lodge. Any Lodge can offer this to its new Master Masons.

The realisation that this is the beginning

The most important thing a mentor helps a new Master Mason understand after the ceremony is that the Third Degree is not the end. It is the beginning.

The Master Mason who looks up from the summit finds that the view is wider than he expected. There is the Lodge to serve, the Province to engage with, the Royal Arch to consider in time. And there are the years of learning, reflection, and service that make a Master Mason not just a title but a way of being in the world.

The four principles at the Third Degree

Prepare means ensuring the candidate arrives ready in every practical sense — knowing the format and general structure without having the ritual revealed, advised to arrive well rested and having eaten, reassured he will be guided and supported at every step. It also means preparing him emotionally — naming the ceremony's weight honestly without diminishing its power.

Guide means re-introducing him to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon and their roles on the night. Explaining that the Third Degree represents the completion of the Craft journey. Revisiting the Masonic values and discussing how they are embodied in the degree's central lesson. Signposting to Solomon and the Hertfordshire Provincial website. Explaining the Master Mason's apron in the depth it deserves. Introducing or reinforcing DAWG.

Support means reassuring that the ceremony is entirely symbolic, safe and conducted with dignity and respect. Explaining what comes after — this is not the end but the real beginning. Beginning to identify questions that may lead in time toward the Royal Arch. Discussing work/life/Masonic balance: Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always. Checking in within 48 hours of the ceremony. Highlighting the value of continued LOI attendance.

Enlighten means discussing the moral themes of the Third Degree — mortality, integrity, and the life well lived. Encouraging reflection on what it means to live respected and die regretted. Explaining the extended working of the Master Mason's apron and its rich symbolism. Discussing the three great principles of Freemasonry — Brotherly Love, Relief, and Truth. Encouraging fuller participation in Lodge workings. Introducing the concept of the Royal Arch as the completion of Pure Antient Masonry — informational, not recruitment, at the right time.

Chapter Ten

Building Together: The Royal Arch

In 1813, at the Articles of Union between the two great Masonic bodies, a declaration was made that has shaped English Freemasonry ever since. Pure Antient Masonry, it was agreed, consists of three degrees, including the Supreme Order of the Holy Royal Arch.

This is not a footnote. It is a constitutional statement of what Freemasonry is. The Royal Arch is, in the words of the United Grand Lodge of England, the completion of the Third Degree — the fourth part of a single, continuous journey that began on the night of Initiation.

One journey, not two

The mentor who understands the Royal Arch will introduce it to the new Master Mason not as a separate organisation requiring a separate commitment, but as the natural continuation of what he has already begun. The Royal Arch is where the story finds its resolution and the journey its completion.

Information, not recruitment

Let us be clear about something the mentoring relationship must protect against: the difference between informing a Master Mason about the Royal Arch and recruiting him into a Chapter. The moment a mentor begins to advocate for a particular Chapter's need for new Companions, rather than focusing on what is right for the individual Master Mason, the mentoring relationship has been compromised.

The conversation should be honest and complete: what the Royal Arch is and its place in Pure Antient Masonry, what a Master Mason can expect from the experience, and — crucially — that the Craft is complete and meaningful in itself, and that there is no obligation, pressure, or expectation to proceed at any particular time.

Timing — everyone is different

When should a mentor first introduce the subject of the Royal Arch? The honest answer is that there is no universal answer. Everyone is different, and it is about ensuring it is the right time for the person — not the right time for the Lodge, the Chapter, or the mentor's own sense of how the journey should unfold.

The four principles in the Royal Arch

Prepare means ensuring sufficient time has passed since the raising. When the moment is right, explaining the format, location and general structure without revealing ritual detail. Outlining the additional time and financial commitment honestly and without pressure. Ensuring he knows the dress code and etiquette, the officers and their different titles.

Guide means explaining clearly that the Royal Arch is the completion of Pure Antient Masonry — not a separate organisation but the fourth part of one continuous journey. Signposting to Solomon and the Hertfordshire Provincial website. Explaining the narrative of the Royal Arch and how it resolves what the Third Degree left open. Making clear that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself — the decision must be his alone.

Support means maintaining regular contact during the period between the raising and any decision about the Royal Arch — not to nudge or persuade, but to remain present. Discussing work/life/Masonic balance before any additional commitment is considered. If he proceeds, supporting him through the joining process. After exaltation, checking in as carefully as after his Initiation.

Enlighten means sharing what the Royal Arch offers — completion, resolution, a new community, new dimensions of symbolism. Discussing the themes of discovery, restoration, the recovery of what was lost. Encouraging reflection on how the Royal Arch completes the journey that began at Initiation. The Royal Arch is not the end of mentoring. It is simply the next conversation.

Which is, of course, exactly as it should be.

Chapter Eleven

Esoteric and Symbolic Teaching: How to Guide Without Lecturing

Pick up your phone and search for Freemasonry. Within seconds you will find yourself in a landscape of extraordinary variety — some of it illuminating, much of it inaccurate, and a not insignificant portion of it ranging from the fanciful to the frankly alarming. The new Mason who has done his research arrives carrying some combination of these sources in his head. He needs someone to help him navigate. That someone is his mentor.

Reliable foundations

In Hertfordshire, the approach is clear and consistent: signpost to Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and to the Hertfordshire Provincial website. These are authoritative, accurate, and written with the actual Mason in mind.

Solomon in particular is a resource of remarkable depth. The DAWG messages — the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team — deliver daily snippets of Masonic learning directly to a member's phone. The obligation to make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge is one of the oldest a Mason takes. DAWG makes it achievable in two minutes over a morning coffee.

The mentor who lectures

There is a particular type of mentor who is genuinely knowledgeable about Masonic symbolism and history, who has read widely and thought deeply, and who — with the best possible intentions — cannot resist sharing all of it. At every festive board. In every conversation. The effect of his approach is almost always the opposite of what he intends.

The new Mason who is subjected to an unsolicited seminar on the symbolism of the compasses at every meeting does not develop a deeper love of Masonic symbolism. He develops a strategy for avoiding certain conversations.

The antidote is simple to state and demanding to practise: follow the mentee's curiosity, not your own.

The danger of over-mystification

There is a related problem: the mentor who treats Masonic symbolism as a mystery to be guarded rather than a gift to be shared. This mentor speaks of the esoteric dimensions of the Craft in hushed tones. He implies that the deeper meanings are accessible only to those who have spent decades in preparation. This is not the esoteric tradition. It is mystification.

Every Mason has the right to explore the symbolism of the Craft at his own pace and in his own direction. The mentor's role is to open doors, not to stand in front of them.

The two chisels in saltire

If there is a single symbol that a mentor might use as a natural entry point into Masonic symbolism, it is the one the mentor already wears.

The Mentor's Jewel, consisting of two chisels in saltire, is not a piece of decorative regalia. It is a statement of philosophy. The chisel is the tool of the craftsman — the instrument of precision, of shaping, of careful and deliberate work. The two chisels in saltire represent the duality at the heart of every mentoring relationship. The mentor's guidance and the mentee's effort are both necessary. Neither is sufficient alone.

Explaining this — not as a formal presentation, but as a natural conversation, perhaps when the mentee notices the Jewel and asks about it — is an illustration of how esoteric teaching works at its best. It begins with what is visible and immediate. It moves, gently, into what is symbolic and meaningful. And it ends not with a conclusion but with a question: what do you make of that?

Symbolism follows the person

Different things resonate with different men. The man who comes from a background in architecture will find the working tools immediately accessible. The man drawn to philosophy will find the deeper themes of the degrees endlessly fertile. The mentor's role is not to provide answers. It is to accompany the enquiry.

PART IV

The Practical Mentor

Tools, Skills and Lodge Culture

Chapter Twelve

The Art of Masonic Conversation

There is a question that every mentor should have ready for the moment after a ceremony. A question that costs nothing, requires no preparation, and opens more doors than almost anything else a mentor can say.

What did you make of tonight?

Six words. No leading. No assumption about what the answer should be. Just a genuine, open invitation for the mentee to tell the truth about his experience — whatever that truth happens to be.

The closed question and the open question

Most of us, in everyday conversation, ask far more closed questions than we realise. Closed questions are the ones with a finite range of answers — yes or no, good or bad, fine or not fine. They are efficient. And they are almost entirely useless in a mentoring context, because efficiency is not what a mentoring conversation is for.

Did you enjoy the ceremony? — closed. What did you make of tonight? — open. The answer could go anywhere. All of those answers are valuable. None of them would have emerged from the closed version.

The art of listening

Asking a good question is only half the discipline. The other half — and arguably the harder half — is what happens after the question is asked.

Genuine listening means suspending your own agenda entirely and giving your full attention to what the person in front of you is actually saying — not just the words, but the tone, the hesitations, the things that are almost said and then pulled back.

The mentor who fills the silence

The mentor who fills every silence with his own experience is not listening. He is performing generosity — the appearance of sharing himself in a way that is actually about his own need to be heard. The antidote: when a silence falls, resist the instinct to fill it. Count to three, internally, before speaking. In the majority of cases, the mentee will fill the silence himself — and what he says in those three seconds will be more honest than anything that came before it.

The festive board as a mentoring environment

Of all the spaces in which Masonic conversation happens, the festive board is the most underestimated and the most powerful. The Lodge room calls for a certain formality.

The festive board dispenses with that formality and replaces it with something more human — the easy conversation of men who are glad to be in each other's company.

The festive board is also the place where What did you make of tonight? finds its most natural home. Not asked with a clipboard and a follow-up framework, but asked over a glass of wine, in the easy atmosphere of the evening's end.

Between meetings

Masonic mentoring does not happen only in the Lodge or at the festive board. It happens in the spaces between — the text message the day after a ceremony, the phone call a week later, the chance encounter at a Provincial event. The mentor who is only available in formally Masonic settings is a mentor with limited reach.

The conversation that matters most is the one that happens when something has gone wrong — when the mentee is struggling and needs to talk it through. These conversations cannot be scheduled. They happen because the relationship has been built carefully enough that the mentee knows, without having to think about it, that this is someone he can talk to.

Chapter Thirteen

Practical Tools and Meeting Guides

Everything in the preceding chapters is only as valuable as its practical expression. A mentor who understands the theory but does not know what to actually do when he sits down with his mentee has been given a map without a compass. This chapter provides the compass.

It is built around a single central tool: the Mentor Meeting Guide, structured around the four principles of Prepare, Guide, Support, and Enlighten. This guide is not a script. It is a framework — a set of prompts and reminders that helps a mentor ensure that every significant conversation covers what it should.

Why structure matters — and where it ends

Structure matters because without it, mentoring becomes reactive rather than proactive. The mentor who has no framework tends to address whatever comes up — the immediate question, the obvious concern — and to neglect what does not present itself. The things that do not present themselves are often the most important.

But structure ends where the person begins. The framework is a servant of the mentoring relationship, not its master.

The Mentor Meeting Guide

Before the meeting — prepare yourself. Review where your mentee is in his Masonic journey. What has happened since your last conversation? Are there ceremonies or LOI evenings coming up? Is there anything in his life outside the Lodge that might be affecting his engagement?

Opening — create the space. Begin with an open question: What did you make of tonight? How have things been since we last spoke? Is there anything on your mind about your Masonry? What are you curious about at the moment? Then listen. Do not fill the silence.

Prepare — has he got what he needs? Does he know what is coming up? Has he been given the practical information he needs? If a ceremony is approaching, has he been properly prepared? Are there practical concerns about time, cost, or travel that have not been addressed?

Guide — does he know where to look? Has he been introduced to Solomon, the Provincial website, and DAWG? Does he know about the social opportunities within the Province? Has he been encouraged to visit other Lodges? Does he understand the structure of the Province and how he can engage beyond his own Lodge room?

Support — how is he actually doing? How is he finding his Masonic journey overall? Is he enjoying himself? Is there anything that is not working? How is the balance between Freemasonry and everything else in his life? Does he feel welcomed and included?

Warning signs to notice: a vagueness or deflection when asked about enjoyment; missed meetings or LOIs without explanation; mentions of financial or time pressure

that have recurred; a reduction in the enthusiasm that characterised earlier conversations.

Enlighten — what is he curious about? What questions has he been carrying? Is there a symbol, a ceremony, or a piece of history that he has been thinking about? One open question that works well: Is there anything from your Masonry recently that you've found yourself thinking about afterwards?

Closing — what happens next? End with clarity about when you will next be in touch, and whether there is anything specific either of you will do before then. Keep it light and natural.

Using the guide across the journey

The content of each section naturally shifts as the mentee progresses. What a mentor needs to Prepare an applicant for is entirely different from what he needs to Prepare a Fellow Craft for. The framework remains constant. The content is always personal.

A note on frequency

In the early stages — from application through to the Third Degree — regular contact is important. As the mentee becomes more established, the formal frequency can reduce while the quality of the relationship deepens. The relationship never ends. Its character simply evolves.

Chapter Fourteen

Lodge Culture and the Mentor's Role

A photograph appeared online. A Mason, proud of his Freemasonry, wearing his jewels. The picture was public. The jewels were in the wrong order — the Chapter jewel, which should sit closest to the heart, was not in its correct position.

In one Lodge, the response was a quiet word at the side — a friendly, private conversation in which the correct positioning was explained, along with the reasoning and meaning behind it. The Mason who received that conversation went away understanding something he had not understood before. He remembers it to this day — not with embarrassment, but with gratitude.

In another Lodge, the response was criticism. The kind that makes a man feel foolish rather than informed. The Mason who received that response remembered it too. But what he remembered was not the lesson. It was the shame.

Same situation. Same mistake. Two entirely different choices about how to respond to it. And two entirely different outcomes.

Culture is owned by all

It is tempting to locate responsibility for Lodge culture in one place. But culture is not owned by the officers. It is owned by every member of the Lodge, equally, because every member contributes to it with every choice they make.

Positivity breeds positivity. So does its opposite. The choice of which to breed belongs to every person in the room.

The Lodge of Instruction — the backbone of Lodge culture

Of all the regular activities in the life of a Lodge, the one that does the most to shape its culture is the one that receives the least formal attention: the Lodge of Instruction. The LOI is where the real work of the Lodge happens. Not the ceremonial work — the human work. The repetition and refinement that turns a nervous newcomer into a confident officer. The informal conversations that happen around the edges of the rehearsal.

A Lodge that values its LOI is a Lodge that values its people.

Moving forward while honouring tradition

Every Lodge carries traditions. But tradition can become a barrier as well as a bond. The Lodge that resists every change on the grounds that things have always been done this way has confused the preservation of tradition with the refusal of growth.

Technology is a good example. The Lodge that uses a WhatsApp group for informal communication, that makes its meeting dates and minutes accessible digitally, that signposts to Solomon as a matter of course — that Lodge is not betraying its traditions. It is honouring them by ensuring they survive long enough to be passed on. The DAWG messages are a perfect illustration of this balance. The obligation to make a daily

advancement in Masonic knowledge is centuries old. Delivering it through a WhatsApp group is entirely contemporary.

Circular mentoring as cultural practice

A Lodge that embodies circular mentoring is a Lodge in which experience and seniority create stewardship rather than hierarchy. The Past Master does not sit apart, dispensing wisdom. He sits within the Lodge, still learning, still curious, still willing to be surprised by what a man twenty years his junior might show him about the Craft.

Setting that example is the most powerful mentoring tool available. The mentor who lives what he teaches — who treats the newest EA with the same genuine interest he brings to a conversation with the Provincial Grand Master — shapes the culture of the Lodge more effectively than any programme ever could.

Culture is not what a Lodge says it values. It is what it does, every meeting night, in a thousand small choices that accumulate into something every member can feel. Make those choices well.

Chapter Fifteen

When Mentoring Gets Difficult

Real mentoring includes the evenings when the conversation doesn't flow. The mentee who seems to be drifting and won't say why. The man whose life outside the Lodge has changed in ways that have quietly changed his relationship with Freemasonry. The moment when the mentor realises that what is needed is beyond what he can provide alone.

These situations are not failures. They are part of the work.

Family, Work, Masonry — in that order, always

There is something I say to every Brother who tells me he cannot attend a meeting because of work, or because of a family celebration, or because something at home needs his presence.

Family, Work, Masonry — in that order, always.

I say it firmly, and I mean it, and I say it because I learned it the hard way. The man whose life has shifted — whose circumstances have changed in ways that make the previous level of Masonic commitment impossible for now — does not need pressure. He needs someone to say: your family comes first. Your work comes second. Your Masonry will be here when you are ready. Come back when you can.

When circumstances change

The man whose circumstances have changed is not disengaged. He is managing. And the mentor who understands that Freemasonry must fit into a life, rather than demand that life fit around it, is the mentor who keeps the door open for the man who needs to step back temporarily.

The question that matters is not Why aren't you attending? It is How can we help? Those two questions produce entirely different conversations. The first puts a man on the defensive. The second opens a door.

I have experienced this from the inside. When my father-in-law — the patriarch of our family, a man I owe an incalculable debt of wisdom and love to — was diagnosed with an inoperable brain tumour, the balance of everything shifted. Hospital visits. Watching a man of enormous dignity and strength regress, gradually and painfully. My wife in turmoil. My family grieving a loss that had not yet happened but was already present in every room. And my wife pregnant with our third child.

I was Senior Warden at the time, due to progress to the Chair. And I found, in that period, that the Lodge's response was not what I needed. Whether or not that was the Lodge's intention — and I believe it was not — what I felt was that the institution's

priorities were placed ahead of the individual's. That matters, because in matters of feeling, perception is everything.

My father-in-law died two weeks before my third child was born. The only image my daughter has of him is a remembrance card placed on her at the funeral — a photograph taken by my brother in a moment of extraordinary foresight and love. Without that photograph, she would have nothing to hold on to.

I tell that story not to criticise, but to illustrate. The mentor who recognises the weight a Brother is carrying — who asks how he can help rather than when he will return — is the mentor who keeps a man's connection to the Craft alive during the periods when he cannot maintain it himself.

When ritual becomes a pressure

The man who struggles with ritual — whether because of a learning difficulty, a poor memory under pressure, or genuine fear of public performance — is in a vulnerable position. The mentor's role is to reduce the pressure, not add to it.

The Hertfordshire approach is explicit: ritual can take as long as each individual needs, and no one should feel overwhelmed. This is not a lowering of standards. It is a recognition that standards are best met when the person meeting them is supported rather than pressured.

When the relationship breaks down

Not every mentoring relationship works. Sometimes two people simply do not connect in the way that effective mentoring requires. When this happens, the worst response is to persist in the hope that things will improve on their own.

The right response is honesty — handled with care, communicated through the Lodge Mentor, and framed always around the mentee's needs rather than the mentor's feelings. The mentee should never be made to feel that the breakdown is his fault. The relationship was not the right one. That is all. Another will be.

Knowing when to step back and refer

There will be moments in every mentoring relationship when the situation exceeds what a Personal Mentor can handle alone. Knowing when to refer is not a failure of mentoring. It is one of its most important functions.

The referral pathways are clear. The Lodge Mentor. The Lodge Almoner. The Provincial Mentoring Team. And beyond Freemasonry, professional services for situations that no Masonic structure can or should attempt to address.

When it feels personal

The mentor who has invested genuinely in a mentoring relationship and watches his mentee disengage or leave will feel something. Disappointment. A question about what he could have done differently.

These feelings are human and legitimate. But they should also be kept in perspective. The mentor who did his job well has done what was within his power. What was beyond his power was never his to control.

Failure, as we established in the earliest pages of this book, is not something to be feared. It is something to be learned from. That principle applies to mentors as much as to anyone else.

PART V

Character, Stories and the Long View

Chapter Sixteen

Personal Development and Character Building

There is a phrase spoken at every Installation of a Worshipful Master that I have heard many times and that, on one particular evening, landed differently from all the others.

Live respected, and die regretted.

Five words. They do not require explanation or unpacking. They state, with a simplicity that is almost startling, the entire moral ambition of Freemasonry — not as a philosophical position to be debated, but as a personal standard to be lived.

I want to be honest in this chapter, in a way that the preceding ones have not quite required. Because personal development — real personal development, the kind that Freemasonry at its best enables — is not a comfortable subject. It involves failure. It involves the periods when the values we profess are tested by circumstances we did not choose.

Family, Work, Masonry — in that order, always

There is something I say to every Brother who tells me he cannot attend a meeting because of work or family. Family, Work, Masonry — in that order, always. I say it firmly, and I mean it, because I learned it the hard way.

In my mid-twenties, my life was spinning. I was in a good Lodge, but the distance was a problem, the commitment felt overwhelming. I stepped back. And when I returned — joining a Lodge closer to home, with people of similar age, a strong LOI, good ritual and good people who cared about it — something shifted.

And then everything changed.

The weight of the world

My father-in-law was the alpha male of our family. The oldest of four Italian brothers who had come from nothing in Naples, crossed to England with their mother, and built lives of genuine substance through nothing but determination and integrity. He was the father of my wife, the Nonno to my children. A man of profound practical wisdom — earned rather than learned. He once said something to me I have never forgotten: if you can't afford it, don't buy it. Live within your means.

When he was diagnosed with an inoperable brain tumour, the shift in the balance of everything was incalculable. Hospital visits. Long evenings watching a man of immense dignity and strength regress, gradually and painfully. My wife in turmoil. My family grieving. And my wife pregnant with our third child.

I was Senior Warden at the time, due to progress to the Chair.

What I felt — rightly or wrongly — was that the Lodge was more concerned with its own programme than with the mental health of the man it was asking to fill the Chair. That may not have been the truth. But it was my truth. And in matters of feeling, perception is everything.

My father-in-law died two weeks before my third child was born. The only image my daughter has of him is a remembrance card placed on her at the funeral — a photograph taken by my brother in a moment of extraordinary foresight and love. Without that photograph, she would have nothing to hold on to.

My absence from Masonry after that period was longer than it should have been. I rethought my work-life balance seriously during that time, and the conclusions I reached have shaped everything that followed. The businesses I run now are run differently because of what I learned in that year. The priorities I hold — Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always — are held with the conviction of someone who has felt the cost of getting the order wrong.

When I came back to Masonry, I came back differently. With more clarity about what I wanted from it and what I was able to give. And, eventually, through a combination of chance and something that feels, in retrospect, like the Craft working as it should, I found my way to the Lodge and the people I needed. That story belongs in the next chapter.

The long view of character

Character is not built quickly. The development of a human being's character is a slow process, shaped by experiences and relationships and decisions that accumulate gradually into something that can, eventually, be called a life well lived.

Freemasonry has always understood this. The rough ashlar is not polished in a single session. The work is continuous, and it is never quite finished. The man I am now is different from the man who joined Freemasonry in his early twenties — not because Freemasonry has changed me in some dramatic way, but because it has consistently held a mirror up and asked me to look honestly at what I see.

Integrity — doing the right thing when nobody is watching

Of the four values, Integrity is the one I feel most strongly about. Not because it is the most important — all four are necessary — but because it is the most demanding in practice.

Integrity is easy to profess and difficult to live. It is not about the choices we make when people are watching. It is about the choices we make when nobody will know. When the only thing standing between us and the convenient path is our own sense of who we are and who we want to be.

Live respected, and die regretted.

How mentoring changes the mentor

The mentor who invests genuinely in another man's development will find, if he is paying attention, that the investment changes him as much as it changes his mentee.

The discipline of listening carefully makes him a better listener in every other context. The habit of asking open questions makes him more curious and less assumptive.

The most powerful illustration of this in my own Masonic life comes in the next chapter. It is the story of a neighbour, a suit, a briefcase, and a friendship that became one of the finest examples of reciprocal mentoring I have ever known.

The mentor as model

The most powerful thing a mentor can do is simply be a man of integrity — in his mentoring relationship, in his Lodge, in his life. To keep his word. To show up when he said he would. To treat his mentee with the same respect and care that he would want to receive himself.

This is how character is transmitted from one generation of Masons to the next. Not through ritual alone. But through the relationship between one man and another — the patient, consistent, unglamorous work of being present, being honest, and being the kind of Mason that others become better by knowing.

Live respected, and die regretted.

It is not a complicated standard. But it is a demanding one. And it is, I have come to believe, the most honest summary of what Freemasonry asks of the men who belong to it — and what the best of them give in return.

Chapter Seventeen

Stories from the Lodge

There is a particular kind of Masonic story that cannot be invented. It does not follow the arc that a writer would choose. It happens sideways, through coincidence and circumstance, through the kind of moment that you only recognise as significant long after it has passed.

This is one of those stories.

The suit and the briefcase

I had moved into a new house. My neighbour — a man I did not yet know — left for work one morning carrying a briefcase and wearing a suit. Ordinary enough. Except that the suit had a particular quality to it, and the briefcase had a particular shape, and something in the combination — some instinct built from years of Masonic life — told me that this man might be a Freemason.

I was right.

We exchanged details. We visited each other's Lodges. And what began as a neighbourly suspicion confirmed across a driveway became, over time, one of the most significant Masonic relationships of my life.

W.Bro Robin Crozier is a member of Amwell Lodge 6459. He is also my mentor. And I am his.

That is not a loose use of the word. It is a precise one. Robin and I mentor each other — genuinely, actively, in both directions. He has things to teach me and I have things to teach him, and we have both been honest enough about that to let the teaching flow wherever it needs to flow. He was one of the people whose understanding of the mentoring relationship — its circularity, its refusal to respect hierarchy — shaped the thinking that runs through this book.

The man I spotted across the driveway became my neighbour, then my Brother, then my mentor, then my mentee, then both at once. Freemasonry does not always work like this. But when it does, it is extraordinary.

What reciprocal mentoring looks like

Reciprocal mentoring is not two people taking turns to mentor each other. It is something more organic — a relationship in which both parties remain genuinely open to learning from the other, in which the direction of insight shifts naturally depending on what is needed in any given conversation.

Robin has experience and perspective that I do not have. I have experience and perspective that he does not have. Neither set is superior. Both are useful. And the conversations that emerge from the combination are richer than either of us could produce alone.

The Provincial environment that made the difference

When I began attending Provincial meetings and events — reconnecting with Freemasonry at a level beyond my own Lodge — something struck me. The environment was different. The mentoring culture was not something being imposed from above. It was simply present — in the way experienced Masons engaged with newer ones, in the quality of the ritual and the LOI, in the sense that people genuinely cared about the experience of every Brother in the room.

I had told myself I wanted to sit in the wings. The wings, it turned out, were not where I belonged. Not because I was pushed — nobody pushed me — but because the environment was one in which engagement felt natural. I am now a Past Master of Amwell Lodge 6459. And I would not have it any other way.

The Errol Uttridge Cup

Amwell Lodge 6459 and Old Hertfordians Lodge share a Chapter. They also play for the Errol Uttridge Cup — a friendly competition named in memory of W.Bro Errol Uttridge, a member of Amwell who was a permanently invited guest at Old Hertfordians. The Cup keeps him present. The two Lodges continue to meet, to compete, to laugh at each other and with each other, to maintain a bond that his presence created and that his passing deepened.

This is what Lodge character looks like over time. A living memory, carried forward by men who knew Errol and men who never met him but who play for his Cup all the same.

Live respected, and die regretted.

Errol Uttridge lived respected. He is, every year the Cup is played, regretted.

That is Freemasonry at its finest. And it is the standard that every Lodge, every mentor, and every Brother has the capacity to reach.

Chapter Eighteen

Building a Mentoring Lodge

There is a moment in the life of some Lodges — not all, but some — when something shifts.

It does not announce itself. There is no resolution passed, no formal programme launched, no Provincial directive that causes it. It is quieter than that, and more significant. It is the moment when enough of the right people, in the same place at the same time, begin making the same kinds of choices — about how they welcome a newcomer, about how they respond to a mistake, about whether they sit with the new EA at the festive board or stay with the people they already know — and the cumulative effect of those choices becomes visible.

This moment cannot be manufactured. But it can be created.

One good mentor. One good relationship.

The Lodge that is trying to build a mentoring culture does not need to transform itself overnight. It needs one thing first: one good mentor, genuinely investing in one good relationship.

A single mentoring relationship done well is visible. Other members of the Lodge see what it looks like when someone is properly looked after. And some of them, not all but some, begin to replicate it. Not because they have been asked to, but because they have seen what it produces.

Positivity breeds positivity. The Lodge does not need to wait for every member to change at once. It needs one person to begin, and then to trust the ripple.

Winning hearts and minds without imposing

The Lodge that tries to impose a mentoring culture will fail. Men who are told they must mentor, who feel that mentoring is being done to the Lodge rather than by it, will comply superficially and resist genuinely.

The Lodge that builds a mentoring culture by example, by invitation, and by creating the conditions in which the right behaviours feel natural — that Lodge will succeed. Not quickly, but durably.

Embedding mentoring so it survives

The greatest risk to any mentoring culture is the departure of the people who built it. If the culture lives only in those individuals — if it has not been embedded in the Lodge's structures and habits — it will fade when they do.

Mentoring becomes embedded when it is part of how the Lodge talks about itself, when the Lodge Mentor's report is given the same weight as the Treasurer's, when the question how are we doing with our new members is asked as a matter of course.

Succession — the most important appointment a mentor makes

Here is something that is rarely said about mentoring roles, and that I feel strongly about: from the moment you accept an appointment as Lodge Mentor, you should be thinking about who will replace you.

Not because you are planning to leave. But because the measure of a good Lodge Mentor is not what the Lodge looks like during his tenure. It is what the Lodge looks like after it.

The Lodge Mentor who develops his successor — who identifies, early in his time, the Brother who has the qualities the role requires, who involves that Brother in the work, who gradually creates the conditions in which the handover is seamless — leaves the Lodge stronger than he found it.

This principle applies beyond the Lodge Mentor role. Every mentor should be developing the next generation of mentors. Not formally, not as a programme — but naturally, through the example of how they work, through the conversations they have about mentoring with the Brothers around them.

The Mentor's Jewel says it clearly: because Brethren, we are all Mentors and must take ownership of our future.

The Provincial scaffold

The Lodge does not build its mentoring culture alone. The Province exists, in part, to make Lodge-level mentoring more possible — to provide the framework, the training, the resources, and the community of practice that no single Lodge could sustain by itself.

In Hertfordshire, this scaffold is well developed. The monthly Microsoft Teams drop-in for Lodge Mentors on the first Tuesday of every month at 7pm. The mentoring documents that provide consistent, accurate, practically useful guidance at every stage of the journey. The DAWG messages. The Provincial meetings and events. The Fleet House Light Blues Club. These structures matter. They provide consistency, continuity, and the reassurance that no Lodge Mentor is working alone.

But the scaffold is not the building. The building is what happens in each Lodge, each meeting night, through the choices each member makes.

Bringing the book full circle

We began, in the Foreword, with two images from my own Masonic life. The LOI I missed, and the reception that greeted my return — the jokes about who I was, the implication that absence required explanation rather than understanding. And, set against it, the evening in Gosport when two newly initiated Brothers were met at the door by a Lodge Mentor who sat with them, explained the evening, and left them feeling welcomed.

The distance between those two experiences is not large. It is not the distance between a good Lodge and a bad one. It is the distance between one choice and another.

Between asking why aren't you attending and asking how can we help. Between filling a silence with your own experience and listening long enough to hear someone else's.

That distance — small in principle, vast in consequence — is what this book has been trying to close.

The question we set out to answer was not how do we keep members. It was the one that W.Bro Mark Butcher has always asked, and that this Province has tried to make its north star: how do we make Freemasonry so rewarding that men never want to leave?

The answer is a culture. A way of being. A set of choices made, every meeting night, by every person in the room.

It is the Lodge Mentor who arrives early and stays late. The Personal Mentor who sends a message the day after a ceremony. The experienced Mason who chooses a different seat at the festive board. The Past Master who attends the LOI even when he has no work to do. The Worshipful Master who, from the first day of his year, is already thinking about the man who will sit in his chair when the year is done.

It is the mentor who begins his tenure already preparing his successor. It is the Lodge that plants seeds it will not always be there to harvest. It is the Brother who treats every Mason he meets — new or experienced, confident or uncertain, present or drifting — as someone whose Masonic life is worth investing in.

Here's to your health — and may Freemasonry flourish, root and branch.

That toast does not belong only to the mentor receiving his Jewel. It belongs to every Mason who has ever chosen, in some small way, to make the Lodge a better place than he found it.

This book is an invitation to make that choice. Every meeting night. For the rest of your Masonic life.

The work is never finished. That is not a burden. It is the whole point.

APPENDICES

The Hertfordshire Mentoring Framework

Appendix A — Mentoring Applicants

The following framework sets out the four principles of Prepare, Guide, Support and Enlighten as applied to the applicant stage — before Initiation has taken place.

Prepare

Ensure the applicant process and timeframes are explained. Explain the format and location of the interview. Outline the time and financial commitments expected. Give an overview of how the interview will be undertaken. Detail who will be present at the interview and what their roles in the Lodge are. Inform them of the dress code for the interview. Ensure they know the start and duration of the interview.

Guide

Signpost to www.ugle.org.uk and www.pglherts.org for information on Freemasonry in general. Signpost to www.mcf.org.uk for information on the Freemasons' Charitable Foundation. Give helpful hints on how to conduct themselves at the interview and the sort of attributes others will be looking for. Outline the type of questions that will be asked. Understand what the candidate is looking for themselves in Freemasonry.

Support

Do they need any help with the process? Do they have any needs that need to be accommodated? Check in with them the day before the interview. Do they have contact numbers in case something happens on the day?

Enlighten

Explain the Guiding Principles of Freemasonry: Integrity, Friendship, Respect and Service. Explain that ceremonies are based around three principles: look after those less fortunate, improve yourself, and live life well so as to be remembered for the right reasons. Explain the current charitable causes being supported by Freemasonry in general and Hertfordshire Province.

Appendix B — First Degree Mentoring

The following framework applies from the point of Initiation through the Entered Apprentice stage.

Prepare

Explain the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail. Ensure they know the etiquette and dress code for the ceremony — punctuality, mobile phone off, cash. Ensure they know they will be expected to speak at the Festive Board. Practical tips: everyone has done this, arrive early, relax, you will be guided at every step.

Guide

Introduce to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon. The purpose of initiation is the symbolic beginning of their Masonic journey. Explain Masonic values of Integrity, Friendship, Respect and Service. Expectations: attendance, contribution, charity and festive boards. Detail the social side, the importance of friendship and the Fleet House Light Blues Club. Signpost to Solomon for further study. Encourage visiting another Lodge's initiation.

Support

Explain the Masonic journey after the First Degree. Questions are encouraged — mentors and Brethren are available after the ceremony. Introduce to the Lodge and Personal Mentor, and explain what a mentor does. Reassure that the ceremony is symbolic, safe and conducted with dignity and respect. Identify questions leading to the Second Degree. Explain what Lodge of Instruction is.

Enlighten

Moral themes: Faith, Hope, Charity, Temperance, Fortitude, Prudence and Justice. Encourage reflection on how the lessons of the First Degree apply personally. Emphasise the wider role of Freemasonry in supporting communities. Explain that there are three degrees, each building on the last, with opportunities for personal growth. DAWG — the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group — administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team.

Appendix C — Second Degree Mentoring

The following framework applies from the point of passing to the Fellow Craft stage.

Prepare

Explain the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail. Ensure they know the etiquette and dress code. Make sure they know they will need to answer questions in Lodge — offer help with practising. Practical tips: everyone has done this, arrive early, trust that they will be guided and supported by the officers throughout.

Guide

Re-introduce to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon. Explain that the purpose of advancement is to build on the symbolic foundation laid in the First Degree. Revisit the Masonic values and discuss how they deepen through knowledge. Expectations: attendance, contribution, charity and active participation in Festive Boards and Lodge of Instruction. Encourage visiting another Lodge's Second Degree.

Support

Explain that the Masonic journey continues beyond the Second Degree. Reinforce that questions are encouraged. Reassure that ritual can take as long as each individual needs — do not feel overwhelmed. The ceremony is symbolic, dignified and entirely safe. Begin to identify areas of curiosity or questions leading to the Third Degree. Highlight the value of Lodge of Instruction.

Enlighten

Discuss the moral and intellectual themes of the Second Degree — the pursuit of knowledge, the development of reason and the building of character. Encourage reflection on how the lessons of diligence, study and self-improvement apply personally and professionally. After the meeting, discuss the working tools up to the Second Degree and their symbolic meaning. After the meeting, discuss the apron and the next steps of a Master Mason's apron. DAWG administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team.

Appendix D — Third Degree Mentoring

The following framework applies from the point of raising to the Master Mason stage.

Prepare

Explain the timing, format and general structure without giving away ritual detail. Ensure they know the etiquette and dress code. Advise them to arrive well rested and having eaten — the ceremony asks something physical of them. Practical reassurance: everyone has done this, you will be guided and supported at every step. Remind them that the ceremony is the most significant of the three degrees and deserves their full presence of mind.

Guide

Re-introduce to the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon and their roles on the night. Explain that the purpose of the Third Degree is the completion of the Craft journey — the symbolic raising of the Mason. Revisit the Masonic values and discuss how they are embodied in the Third Degree's central lesson. Signpost to Solomon and the Hertfordshire Provincial website. Explain the Master Mason's apron — the seven tassels, their connection to the seven liberal arts and sciences and the seven then-known planets of the solar system. Encourage visiting another Lodge's Third Degree as an observer in due course. Introduce or reinforce DAWG.

Support

Reassure that the ceremony is entirely symbolic, safe and conducted with dignity and respect. Questions are welcome — mentors, officers and Brethren are available after the ceremony. Explain what comes after — this is not the end but the real beginning of the Masonic journey. Begin to identify questions that may lead toward the Royal Arch. Discuss work/life/Masonic balance: Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always. Check in within 48 hours of the ceremony. Highlight the value of continued LOI attendance.

Enlighten

Discuss the moral themes of the Third Degree — mortality, integrity and the life well lived. Encourage reflection on what it means to live respected and die regretted. Explain the extended working of the Master Mason's apron and its rich symbolism. Discuss the three great principles of Freemasonry — Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth. Encourage fuller participation in Lodge workings. Introduce the concept of the Royal Arch as the completion of Pure Antient Masonry — informational, not recruitment, at the right time. DAWG administered by the Provincial Mentoring Team.

Appendix E — Royal Arch Mentoring

The following framework applies when a Master Mason is ready to consider the Supreme Degree.

Prepare

Ensure the Master Mason has had sufficient time in the Craft to consolidate his understanding of the three degrees before the Royal Arch is introduced. Explain the format, location and general structure without revealing ritual detail. Outline the additional time and financial commitment honestly and without pressure. Explain who will be present and what their roles are — the Chapter has different officers and titles. Ensure he knows the dress code and etiquette. Practical reassurance: the experience will feel unfamiliar at first, as the Craft did, but he will be guided at every step.

Guide

Explain clearly that the Royal Arch is described by UGLE as the completion of Pure Antient Masonry — the fourth part of one continuous journey. Signpost to Solomon and the Hertfordshire Provincial website. Introduce him to the Chapter and its Companions. Explain the narrative of the Royal Arch and how it resolves the question left open by the Third Degree. Encourage visiting a Chapter meeting as an observer before committing, if appropriate. Make clear that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself — the decision to proceed must be his alone, made freely and without pressure.

Support

Check in regularly during the period between the raising and any decision about the Royal Arch — not to nudge or persuade, but to remain present. Be available to answer questions honestly and accurately. Discuss work/life/Masonic balance before any additional commitment is considered: Family, Work, Masonry, in that order, always. If he proceeds, support him through the joining process. After exaltation, check in as carefully as after his Initiation.

Enlighten

Share what the Royal Arch offers — completion, resolution, a new community, new dimensions of symbolism and learning. Discuss the themes of discovery, restoration and the recovery of what was lost. Encourage reflection on how the Royal Arch connects to and completes the journey that began at Initiation. Introduce DAWG and Solomon's Royal Arch content as resources for deepening understanding. Encourage participation in Provincial Royal Arch meetings and events. Reinforce that every step — Craft and Royal Arch alike — is part of the same commitment to self-improvement, brotherhood and service.

Appendix F — Personal Mentors

The following framework guides Personal Mentors in their one-to-one relationship with members at all stages of their Masonic journey.

Prepare

Familiarise yourself with the member's background and interests. Read the individual guide for their current stage — applicant, EA, FC, MM. Prepare to explain Masonic terminology in simple, clear language. Coordinate with the Lodge Mentor to align with Lodge and Provincial practices.

Guide

Encourage questions and discussions. Guide through dress code, procedures and what is expected. Highlight internal Lodge opportunities, wider Provincial opportunities and the Fleet House Light Blues Club. Share relevant sections from the stage guide to deepen understanding. Sit with them at the Festive Board.

Support

Check in with them regularly to see how they are finding their Masonic journey. Be available to answer questions between meetings. Encourage attendance at social events. Provide reassurance if they feel overwhelmed by ritual or customs. Share your own experiences to normalise any nerves or feeling of being overwhelmed.

Enlighten

Share insights into the deeper meanings and philosophies within Freemasonry. Encourage wider reading on Solomon and the Hertfordshire website. Highlight opportunities for charity and service. Inspire them to consider how they can contribute. Encourage reflective discussions on how each degree's teachings have personal meaning.

A Note from the Author

I want to be honest about why I wrote this book.

It was not because I had all the answers. It was because I had made enough mistakes to know which questions matter.

I have watched good men leave Freemasonry quietly, without anyone noticing until it was too late. I have seen mentoring done badly — not through malice, but through habit, through a refusal to accept that the old way of doing things was no longer working. I have been on the receiving end of it myself, as anyone who read the Foreword will know. And I have, at times, been guilty of the very things I now challenge in others.

Those mistakes are not something I am ashamed of. They are the reason this book exists. Every chapter draws on something I got wrong, saw go wrong, or had to fight to put right. If I had waited until I had a perfect record before putting pen to paper, the book would never have been written — and frankly, it would not have been worth reading.

What I wanted to do — what I hope I have done — is give the men and women involved in Masonic mentoring something practical. Not a set of rules, but a way of thinking. A framework they can pick up, adapt, challenge and make their own. The four principles — Prepare, Guide, Support, Enlighten — are not mine to keep. They belong to anyone willing to use them.

More than anything, I wanted to share what I have seen work. The Lodge Mentor who arrives early. The Personal Mentor who sends a message the morning after a ceremony. The experienced Mason who moves seats at the festive board so the new man does not sit alone. Small choices, made consistently, by ordinary men who understand that mentoring is not a programme — it is a habit.

I enjoy Freemasonry enormously. It has given me friendships I would not trade, lessons I could not have learned anywhere else, and a sense of purpose that runs deeper than I expected when I first knocked on the door in my twenties. I would like every Mason to feel the same way. Not all of them will, and that is fine. But no man should leave the Craft because nobody bothered to help him find what he was looking for.

If this book gives you one idea you had not considered, one conversation you would not otherwise have had, or one reason to think differently about the man sitting next to you at the next meeting — then it has done its job.

The rest is up to you.

Acknowledgements

This book would not exist without the generosity, wisdom and brotherhood of many people, and I want to name some of them.

W.Bro Mark Butcher, Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire, whose mantra — Freemasonry must be fun — is the philosophical heart of this book, and whose mentoring of me has been one of the great privileges of my Masonic life. This book is, in large part, an attempt to share what he has taught.

W.Bro Mark Purtow, Assistant Provincial Grand Master of Hertfordshire, who has mentored me through challenge as much as through support, who has trusted me with small acts that carried great weight, and who has always created a space in which honest disagreement is not just permitted but valued.

W.Bro Robin Crozier, of Amwell Lodge 6459, my neighbour before he was my Brother, whose relationship with me is the finest example of reciprocal mentoring I have known. He mentors me as much as I mentor him, and the book is stronger for that truth.

RW Bro Neil Connolly, Provincial Grand Master of Hertfordshire, for his leadership, example, and understanding that even the most senior figures in the Craft remain students of it.

AW.Bro Keith Dunnet, Assistant Provincial Grand Master of Hertfordshire, who has mentored me by pushing boundaries I would not have pushed myself. Keith had faith in my abilities before I did, and in his own words, he "unleashed" me. Without his belief and his willingness to back it with action, I would not have been in a position to influence the changes I have. That is mentoring at its most effective — not instruction, but trust.

W.Bro Jez Wilson, for his understanding of Lodge character and what makes a Lodge a home. And his homemade fruit cake whilst practicising the ritual in his front rom,

W.Bro Gareth Bezani, whose Installation at Gosport Lodge gave me one of the finest examples of mentoring in action I have ever witnessed.

W.Bro Dan O'Connell, founding member of the Fleet House Light Blues Club, whose principle — no one left in the corner — says everything that needs to be said about what belonging looks like in practice.

The memory of W.Bro Errol Uttridge, of Amwell Lodge, whose name is carried forward every year in the competition between Amwell and Old Hertfordians. He lived respected. He is regretted.

My wife and family, who have always been first. In that order, always.

And to every Mason who has ever asked a question they were afraid to ask, stayed at the LOI longer than they needed to, sat next to the new man at the festive board, or made a Brother feel welcome in a room full of strangers — this book is for you. You were already doing it. I hope this helps you understand why it matters.

About the Author

W.Bro Wes Pierce is the Provincial Junior Grand Deacon and Assistant Grand Mentor of the Province of Hertfordshire. He will take on the role of Provincial Grand Mentor in 2027.

He is the owner of three businesses — Number 8 Safety Ltd (event safety consultancy), Number 8 Hire Ltd (event hire), and Hot Dough Ltd (hospitality). He is the Events Secretary of the Fleet House Light Blues Club and a Past Master of weir Hall 6088 and Amwell Lodge 6459.

Wes joined Freemasonry in his early twenties and has spent more than two decades in the Craft. His approach to mentoring has been shaped by his own experience of both poor and excellent Masonic support, by the philosophy of his mentor W.Bro Mark Butcher, Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire, by the challenge and trust of W.Bro Mark Purtow, Assistant Provincial Grand Master of Hertfordshire, and by the many Brothers whose stories, questions and journeys have taught him more than any book.

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Here's to your health —

and may Freemasonry flourish, root and branch.